In 2017 Kim Jong-un, the secretive thirty-four-year-old leader of North Korea, defied the United States and the international community by choosing July 4, America's Independence Day, to launch an intercontinental ballistic missile capable of reaching Alaska. Later that year he declared his country a "full-fledged nuclear power" whose missiles could hit targets around the globe. In October 2017, when the North Korean media announced the test of a hydrogen bomb, President Donald Trump threatened to "totally destroy North Korea." He declared that "Rocket Man [Kim Jong-un] is on a suicide mission for himself and for his regime." Kim shot back, calling Trump a "mentally deranged old lunatic." In May 2018, President Trump withdrew from the multilateral agreement with Iran that precluded that country from developing nuclear weapons. In January 2020, Iran declared its own withdrawal from the agreement, raising fears of the rapid development of its nuclear capabilities.[2]

As the United States was experiencing the worst nuclear crises since the end of the Cold War, history suddenly became the present. In August 2017, two influential commentators, one a Republican, the future national security adviser to President Trump, John Bolton, the other a Democrat, the former White House chief of staff under President Clinton and CIA director and secretary of defense under President Obama, Leon Panetta, suggested in unison that the US–North Korean standoff over the development of Kim Jong-un's nuclear and missile program was the worst nuclear crisis to hit the world since the standoff over Cuba. In February 2019, Vladimir Putin joined the fray, declaring that he was prepared for a new Cuban-type missile crisis and threatened the United States with supersonic rockets to be installed on ships and submarines off the American coast. He repeated the same statement in February 2020. One month earlier, in January 2020, after the US assassination of Iran's architect of clandestine warfare Qasem Suleimani and Tehran's announcement of Iran's complete withdrawal from the nuclear deal, the US media compared President Trump's nuclear gamble with President Kennedy's actions in the Cuban missile crisis.[3]

The references to the Cuban missile crisis have shown no tendency of disappearing from the world political scene and media any time soon. The return of nuclear weapons to the center stage of international politics inevitably brought back memories of the nuclear stand over Cuba. Can we